

STAGE TEN • RELATIONSHIPS & CONNECTIONS

FIRSTS

Relationships & Connections

SESSION 1

Friendships & Peer Connections

FIRSTS N1-N10

Genuine Friendship Formed

- Proximity $\neq$ genuine friendship
- It takes deliberate investment
- Foundation for the whole section

Peer Support Exchange

- One-directional friendships feel unbalanced
- Specific offers beat vague ones
- Genuine reciprocity sustains real health

Fun/Relaxation Activity with Friends

- Not everything can be transactional
- Often the first thing cut when busy
- Deliberate fun is genuinely sustainable

Conflict Resolution with a Friend

- Avoided conflict often damages more
- Genuine friendships can deepen through it
- Respectful and direct, not avoidant

Appreciation Note to a Friend

- Specific beats generic, every time
- Reinforces what actually made it valuable
- Small action, real relational impact

Reflection on Friendship Qualities

- Convenience $\neq$ genuine compatibility
- Not all friendships share the same qualities
- Sets up N7–N10

Networking through Friendships

- Help friends access your network too
- Specific intros work, vague ones don't
- Builds real goodwill, both directions

Collaborative Study Session

- Can produce deeper understanding than solo
- Structure prevents social drift
- Strengthens the relationship too

Trust-Building Exercise

- Trust deepens through genuine vulnerability
- Surface-level friendships plateau
- Timing and fit genuinely matter

Group Celebration or Milestone Recognition

- Shared milestones strengthen group bonds
- Often passes unacknowledged by default
- Doesn't need to be elaborate

SESSION 2

Project Partners & Teamwork

FIRSTS N11-N20

Project Partner Identified

- The right partner changes everything
- Deliberate beats convenient
- Foundation for the whole section

Task Delegation Practice

- Uneven, implicit delegation breeds resentment
- Discuss it openly, from the start
- Fairness prevents the most common team friction

Team Goal Alignment

- A shared brief $\neq$ shared interpretation
- Confirm explicitly, don't assume
- Costly, avoidable problem otherwise

Collaborative Problem-Solving Session

- Two perspectives beat one, done right
- Hear the other's reasoning first
- Structure prevents one voice dominating

Peer Feedback Exchange

- Ongoing beats end-of-project only
- Catches issues while still fixable
- Build it into the workflow

Accountability Partner Agreement

- Vague intentions don't work
- Specific frequency, specific format
- Extends N12's delegation into a real structure

Group Reflection & Debrief

- Individual reflection alone misses patterns
- Genuine collective discussion, not a status update
- Worth scheduling deliberately

Conflict Mediation in a Team

- Unaddressed conflict festers, affects output
- Collaborative resolution protects both
- Simmering makes it harder later, not easier

Recognition of Team Contributions

- Never rushing straight to the next task
- Specific recognition, not generic praise
- Builds real cohesion and motivation

Leadership or Facilitation Role in a Group

- Don't default to contributor forever
- Builds skills essential for advancement
- Closes the section — lead, don't just contribute

SESSION 3

Mentorship & Professional Connections

FIRSTS N21-N30

Mentor Identified

- Genuine fit beats prestige or title
- Real willingness to invest matters most
- Foundation for N22-N24

Mentor Meeting Scheduled

- Identification alone doesn't build a relationship
- Specific requests beat vague, open ones
- Take the first step yourself

Thoughtful Question to a Mentor

- Question quality drives conversation value
- Tailored beats generic, every time
- Determines how valuable N22 turns out to be

Follow-Up with Mentor

- Relationships fade without follow-up
- Turns one conversation into an ongoing one
- Closes the direct mentor arc

Peer Networking Circle Formed

- Broader than one partner, still genuinely intimate
- Structure prevents drift into purely social
- Mutual investment matters

Industry Contact Made

- Compounds significantly over a career
- Never purely transactional
- Genuine engagement, not just “what can I get”

Coffee Chat with a Professional

- Lower stakes than a formal interview
- That's the actual advantage — use it
- Builds more genuine relationships

Volunteer Collaboration

- Shared purpose builds authentic connection
- More genuine than pure networking events
- The purpose is the point, not the contacts

Peer Recommendation Given

- Give, not just seek
- Specific, genuine knowledge required
- Makes a network mutually beneficial

Reflection on Relationship Growth

- Look across friendships, teams, and mentors together
- Honest, even where it's uncomfortable
- An ongoing practice, not a finished checklist

Stage Ten, Complete

One relationship, named out loud, that you're committing to invest in further.